Located along the 3.5-kilometre Sabarmati riverfront, the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Gandhinagar has rapidly evolved from its modest beginnings in 2008 into one of the country's most forward-thinking engineering institutions. Today, the institute is drawing top-tier talent to its 400-acre state-of-the-art campus and boasts a strength of 3,000 students and 160 faculty members.

While its core engineering programmes continue to thrive, what sets IIT Gandhinagar apart is the academic flexibility and interdisciplinary range it offers. Students can pursue minors in unrelated fields, opt for dual degrees and choose from a diverse basket of electives. For instance, programmes in Archaeological Sciences, Humanities & Social Sciences and Biological Sciences & Engineering are attracting interest beyond traditional streams. "We have a truly credit-based, not prescription-based system. Students can make their own choices and nurture their own capabilities," notes Dr Rajat Moona, the institute's director.

It was in 2015 when IIT Gandhinagar moved into its own campus. Soon after, it began to develop its distinct academic culture. "We visited top universities, spoke to doctoral students, studied their research and invited them to apply here," says Dr Moona. "As a result, we now have a high-quality and diverse talent pool."

The institute has since expanded its programmes, strengthened its infrastructure and cultivated a robust research ecosystem. A supercomputing facility and well-equipped labs support cutting-edge work. Labs are open 24x7 for student-led innovation. "When a new faculty member joins, we ask them to give a proposal for what kind of research equipment they need, what kind of funding they need, and we provide them with that," explains Dr Moona. "We also hire post-doctoral fellows who can work with them. So, a new faculty member becomes productive from day one."

STRATEGIC LOCATION

IIT Gandhinagar's location also gives it strategic advantages. With GIFT City—India's first operational greenfield smart city and international financial services centre—next door and semiconductor manufacturing clusters in Sanand and Dholera, the institute has forged several industry linkages for student engagement and placements. International tie-ups, including with universities setting up their satellite institutes in GIFT City, further enhance global exposure.

Yet, engineering, Dr Moona reminds us, is ultimately about problem-solving. That ethos is embedded in initiatives like the Explorer fellowship, where students live in villages on a small budget, understand real-world issues, and work on grassroots solutions. Last year, the institute also earned the Star Campus Award 2024 from Earth Day Network–India for its outstanding water conservation practices, including two sewage treatment plants, rainwater-harvesting and landscaped campus lakes. The institute's efforts were also certified as 'exemplary' under the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India's 'Eat Right Campus' initiative in February 2025 for its commitment to food safety—testament to the institute's holistic vision of campus living. In every respect—from academics to infrastructure and sustainability—IIT Gandhinagar is shaping up as a model for the next generation of Indian higher education. ■

GURUSPEAK

"We started visiting various universities and talked to doctoral students, looked at their research and encouraged them to apply here. As a result, we are now getting very high-quality and diverse talent that has altered perceptions about the institute"

PROF. RAJAT MOONA
Director, IIT Gandhinagar

STUDENTSPEAK



"Flexible course choices, strong research facilities and approachable faculty are the USP. The month-long foundation programme, which offers much more beyond academics–from interactive sessions to fun games and real-world exposure–stands out. The global alumni network is a big plus"

PRAMIT JOY KALAMANDI
BTech, Chemical Engineering, 3rd year

**College showing highest improvement in scores in past five years*